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HOW CRISIS MANAGEMENT STRATEGIES ADDRESS STAKEHOLDERS' SOCIOCOGNITIVE CONCERNS AND ORGANIZATIONS' SOCIAL EVALUATIONS

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Crises are harmful events that can influence organizational outcomes, leading to significant scholarly and practitioner interest in crisis management. A limitation of this line of inquiry, however, is that it typically glosses over stakeholders' multiple concerns and the multiple factors that comprise organizations' response strategies. To address this limitation, we delineate stakeholders' crisis concerns into rational, emotional, and moral aspects. We then develop a typology along two dimensions of crisis response strategies—*accountability* and *attention*—to predict the likelihood that a specific strategy mitigates each of these concerns. We theorize that certain strategies mitigate just one type of concern, while others mitigate multiple concerns—albeit with a lower likelihood of success. Finally, we apply our typology to an organization's social evaluations—that is, important, proximal outcomes affected by a crisis—in order to better understand the trade-offs associated with managing stakeholders' multiple concerns.

Organizational crises are harmful events perceived by managers and stakeholders as salient, unexpected, and disruptive (Bundy, Pfarrer, Short, & Coombs, 2017). The wide-spanning consequences of a crisis—including to financial performance (e.g., Aebi, Sabato, & Schmid, 2012), employee retention (e.g., Wiersema & Zhang, 2013), and organizational survival (e.g., Marcus & Goodman, 1991)—have led to a substantial body of research on managing crises (e.g., Coombs, 2007; Elsbach, 1994; Gillespie & Dietz, 2009; Kahn, Barton, & Fellows, 2013; Pfarrer, DeCelles, Smith, & Taylor, 2008). In particular, a stream of research has developed around crisis response strategies, defined as a "set of coordinated communication and actions used to influence evaluators' crisis perceptions" (Bundy & Pfarrer, 2015: 346). Crisis management scholars have demonstrated how crisis response strategies can mitigate organizational losses in financial and nonfinancial assets alike, with a particular focus on an organization's social evaluations—stakeholders' socially constructed and collective perceptions of the organization and its actions (e.g., Ashforth & Gibbs, 1990; Benoit, 1995; Gomulya & Boeker, 2014; Lamin & Zaheer, 2012; Lange & Washburn, 2012; Sutton & Callahan, 1987).

A limitation of this line of inquiry, however, is its primary focus on an overall, "one-size-fits-all" crisis response strategy (e.g., Coombs, 2007) in contrast to a more specific exploration of the differential effects of crisis response strategies on different stakeholder concerns (cf. Claeys & Cauberghe, 2014). In particular, past research has often glossed over stakeholders' multiple concerns arising from a crisis, as well as the multiple factors that comprise organizations' response strategies. In reference to stakeholder concerns, crisis management research has typically focused on a single concern or stakeholder reaction, often proxied via social or financial outcomes, such as reputation (e.g., Coombs, 2007) or stock market returns (e.g., Gomulya & Boeker, 2014). Evidence suggests, however, that stakeholders may not react uniformly to

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crises (e.g., Lamin & Zaheer, 2012; Zavyalova, Pfarrer, Reger, & Hubbard, 2016). Acknowledging stakeholder heterogeneity is thus important because if crises evoke different concerns within and across stakeholder groups, it follows that crisis response strategies may only be effective among certain audiences and may only address certain concerns.

In reference to response strategies, most extant theorizing has focused on a single underlying dimension of a response—such as the extent to which an organization accepts responsibility for a crisis—while ignoring other critical elements, such as how an organization directs stakeholders' attention toward the crisis (Bundy et al., 2017; Zavyalova, Pfarrer, Reger, & Shapiro, 2012). This view of response strategies may oversimplify their complexity. For instance, extant work has tended to categorize both reparations in the form of corporate donations (e.g., Marcus & Goodman, 1991) and new organizational policies (e.g., Lamin & Zaheer, 2012) as accepting more responsibility for a crisis (i.e., accommodative). However, they "accommodate" differently, and may address stakeholder concerns in ways that we currently do not understand. Taken together, what we currently theorize to be the most effective strategy may actually be *ineffective* at addressing multiple stakeholder concerns, especially when considering the multidimensionality of crisis response strategies (e.g., Ertug, Yogev, Lee, & Hedström, 2016; Jensen & Kim, 2014; Kim & Jensen, 2014; König, Graf-Vlachy, Bundy, & Little, 2020; Pfarrer, Bundy, Muller, & Wheeler, 2020; Zavyalova et al., 2016).

In this paper, we address the need for a more nuanced approach to crisis management by developing a typology of crisis response strategies and relating it to stakeholders' multiple concerns in three steps. First, we explicate three sociocognitive concerns that stakeholders have in response to a crisis: *rational concerns*, which are related to how a crisis threatens an organization's ability to deliver value (Camerer, Loewenstein, & Prelec, 2005; Slovic, Finucane, Peters, & MacGregor, 2004); *emotional concerns*, which are rooted in the negative affect a crisis evokes toward an organization (Camerer et al., 2005; Slovic et al., 2004; Zajonc, 1980); and *moral concerns*, which arise when a crisis signals value incongruence between an organization and its stakeholders (Black, 1993; Devers, Dewett, Mishina, & Belsito, 2009).

Second, we build a typology that juxtaposes two primary dimensions of crisis response strategies—how an organization handles crisis *accountability* (the extent to which an organization accepts responsibility for its role in the crisis) and how it directs stakeholders' *attention* (the extent to which an organization brings attention toward the crisis and possible remedies) (Bundy et al., 2017; Zavyalova et al., 2012)—to explain how different combinations of crisis response strategies address stakeholders' sociocognitive concerns in different ways. In contrast to current theorizing, our typology suggests that a given response strategy is unlikely to sufficiently address all stakeholder concerns that arise in a crisis, leading to trade-offs for the organization when deciding which concerns to address.

Finally, to demonstrate how these trade-offs manifest in organizational outcomes, we apply our typology to an organization's social evaluations. We take the view that stakeholders' rational, emotional, and moral concerns are the mechanisms by which an organization's social evaluations—its reputation, celebrity, legitimacy, and status—are threatened during a crisis (e.g., Deephouse, Bundy, Tost, & Suchman, 2017; Lange, Lee, & Dai, 2011; Pollock, Lashley, Rindova, & Han, 2019; Washington & Zajac, 2005; Zavyalova, Pfarrer, & Reger, 2017). Accordingly, we theorize that because managers are unable to mitigate all stakeholder concerns effectively, they need to prioritize certain evaluations (e.g., reputation) at the expense of others (e.g., celebrity). Ultimately, our theory suggests that organizations should implement the strategy that most appropriately reflects their prioritized social evaluations.

We contribute to the crisis management and social evaluations literatures in three primary ways. First, we specify the sociocognitive concerns (*rational*, *emotional*, and *moral*) by which crisis scholars can more easily incorporate multiple stakeholders into their theorizing. Second, we detail the effectiveness of organizations' crisis response strategies on stakeholders' various sociocognitive concerns during a crisis. In doing so, we introduce the importance of studying multiple dimensions of crisis response strategies (*accountability* and *attention*) concurrently. Finally, by developing the link between stakeholders' concerns and their social evaluations (*reputation, celebrity, legitimacy,* and *status*), we reveal more practical implications for organizations as a result of how their response strategies mitigate stakeholder concerns.

CRISIS MANAGEMENT AND STAKEHOLDERS' SOCIOCOGNITIVE CONCERNS

Crises come in many forms, including environmental violations, instances of fraud, industrial accidents, labor exploitation, financial restatements, scandals, boycotts, and corporate corruption (e.g., Bundy, Iqbal, & Pfarrer, 2021; Coombs, 2007; Gomulya & Boeker, 2014; Lamin & Zaheer, 2012; McDonnell & King,

2013; Pfarrer, Smith, Bartol, Khanin, & Zhang, 2008; Zhang, Bartol, Smith, Pfarrer, & Khanin, 2008). Crises are also highly consequential for organizations and stakeholders (Bundy et al., 2017). For example, a crisis can influence organizational learning and adaptation (e.g., Lampel, Shamsie, & Shapira, 2009; Veil, 2011), an organization's survival and financial performance (e.g., Marcus & Goodman, 1991), and stakeholders' evaluations of the organization (e.g., Elsbach, 1994; Graffin & Ward, 2010; Graffin, Bundy, Porac, Wade, & Quinn, 2013; Zavyalova et al., 2012, 2016).

Crises are behavioral phenomena, meaning they are socially constructed and a function of the affected parties' sensemaking efforts. Indeed, how organizations and their different stakeholders perceive crises, as well as how crises shape their relationships, is in the eye of the beholder (Iqbal, Bundy, & Pfarrer, 2021; Narayanan, Zane, & Kemmerer, 2011; Powell, Lovallo, & Fox, 2011; Rindova, Reger, & Dalpiaz, 2012). From this, crisis management can be seen as an attempt to "manage meaning" among the heterogeneous stakeholder perceptions of the organization (Coombs, 2010: 478). However, most crisis management research has ignored stakeholder heterogeneity, as it has been more interested in investigating the effectiveness of one-size-fits-all response strategies. For example, a predominant focus in this literature relates to situational crisis communications theory (Coombs, 2007) and the crisis–response match (Bundy & Pfarrer, 2015; Raithel & Hock, 2021), both of which suggest that organizations should be more (less) accommodative when they are perceived as more (less) to blame for causing the crisis—without clear delineation of the audiences whose perceptions are being managed.

While still emerging, some research has acknowledged and integrated stakeholder heterogeneity into the crisis context (e.g., Busenbark, Pfarrer, Miller, & Marshall, 2019; Mishina, Block, & Mannor, 2012; Zavyalova et al., 2016). Some have discerned stakeholders by type of assessment (i.e., dimensions of corporate reputation) rather than by type of stakeholder group (e.g., Bundy et al., 2021; Chandler, Polidoro, & Yang, 2020; Lamin & Zaheer, 2012), while others have grouped stakeholders by characteristics such as organizational identification (e.g., Zavyalova et al., 2016). Overall, this work has suggested that different stakeholders react differently to crises and crisis management strategies.

Yet, we still do not fully understand the relative effectiveness of different crisis response strategies on managing multiple stakeholders. There are two reasons for this. First, research has often studied stakeholders as archetypal groups (e.g., shareholders, employees, the government), which ignores stakeholder heterogeneity both *within* and *between* each group. Second, research has often oversimplified crisis response strategies, relying on descriptions of response strategies instead of explicating the (multiple) mechanisms by which they operate.

Acknowledging stakeholder heterogeneity is thus important because if different stakeholders react differently to crises, it follows that stakeholders may not react uniformly to a given crisis response strategy. Similarly, stakeholders within one group (e.g., shareholders, securities analysts, employees) may not react uniformly to crisis response strategies. From the organization's perspective, then, incorporating this heterogeneity into response strategies can be an important component of the calculus managers undergo when choosing which responses to implement.

To address the limitations of past research, we first specify stakeholder heterogeneity as a function of stakeholders' sociocognitive *concerns*. That is, we place stakeholders along the spectra of the different concerns that arise from a crisis, regardless of their stakeholder group. This approach allows us to move beyond extant theory that considers one stakeholder group (e.g., Petriglieri, 2015) or that compares reactions across specific stakeholder groups (e.g., Lamin & Zaheer, 2012). Instead, we are able to integrate both within- and between-stakeholder group heterogeneity.

In particular, drawing from the sociocognitive literature on information processing (Fiske & Taylor, 1991; Meindl, Stubbart, & Porac, 1994; Rindova et al., 2012), we suggest that stakeholders' concerns during a crisis vary along three distinct aspects by which they process, interpret, and use information stimuli (Meindl et al., 1994; Rindova et al., 2012)—rational, emotional, and moral concerns (Camerer et al., 2005; Kahneman, 2011; Pollock et al., 2019; Slovic et al., 2004; Tost, 2011). Research in cognitive psychology has distinguished these forms of information processing as distinct insofar as they are three different ways in which actors convert stimuli into perceptions (e.g., Fine, 2006; Haidt, 2001; Kahneman, Slovic, & Tversky, 1982; Landy & Goodwin, 2015). These concerns thus mutually interact to help actors make sense of their surroundings, but they are still discernable. We detail each aspect in turn, with specific emphasis on how each one shapes stakeholders' concerns stemming from a crisis. Table 1 acts as a summary of these aspects, including the type of information processing involved, how the information processing leads to concerns, and how organizations may mitigate those concerns—which we further detail when developing Propositions 1–4.

TABLE 1
Stakeholders' Sociocognitive Concerns

Aspect	Type of Information Processing	Resulting Concerns	Methods for Mitigating Concerns
Rational	Conscious and deliberate	Attributions of organization's crisis involvement and reassessment of its capabilities	- Meet stakeholders' informational demands - Reassure stakeholders of organization's capabilities
Emotional	Subconscious and automatic	Increased negative affect and decreased positive affect directed toward the organization	- Increase positive affect toward organization - Redirect negative affect away from organization
Moral	Conscious and subconscious	Perceived value incongruence between the organization and its stakeholders	- Redirect perceptions of immorality away from organization - Highlight unrelated moral acts taken by organization - Signal that organization is providing a remedy

Stakeholders' Sociocognitive Concerns

Stakeholders' *rational concerns* are related to how a crisis threatens an organization's ability to deliver value (Camerer et al., 2005; Slovic et al., 2004). Rational concerns are the result of stakeholders' conscious and deliberate analyses of the crisis and its surrounding context (Kirkpatrick & Epstein, 1992; Slovic, Finucane, Peters, & MacGregor, 2002). In particular, stakeholders assess and evaluate the crisis in order to process how it relates to the organization and to themselves. In this way, stakeholders make initial attributions of (a) who caused the crisis and (b) how it affects the organization's capabilities (Hastie, 1984).

In contrast, stakeholders' *emotional concerns* are rooted in the negative affect toward an organization typically evoked by crises, and often arise more automatically than do rational concerns (Camerer et al., 2005; Slovic et al., 2004; Zajonc, 1980). They are seen as "basic," "inescapable," and subconsciously determined (Zajonc, 1980: 156). As opposed to rational concerns that are focused on what happened and who was responsible, emotional concerns are fundamentally about how the stakeholder feels about the crisis and organization. While emotional concerns may not be outwardly communicated (e.g., Nisbett & Wilson, 1977), they are critical components of stakeholders' perceptions of organizations (e.g., Pollock et al., 2019) and thus need to be mitigated by organizations during a crisis.

Finally, stakeholders' *moral concerns* arise when a crisis signals value incongruence between an organization and its stakeholders (Black, 1993; Devers et al., 2009; Pollock et al., 2019). In contrast to both rational and emotional concerns, moral concerns are a result of both conscious and subconscious processing. First, stakeholders' values—their guiding principles (Schwartz, 1994)—are often derived from conscious, deliberate processing of their experiences, which shape their beliefs regarding organizations' actions or behaviors (Rokeach, 2008; Williams, 1979). Second, there is a more subconscious evaluation of "right or wrong, moral or immoral" (Skitka, Bauman, & Sargis, 2005: 896) that stakeholders automatically undergo. While this too may be based on experiences, it is the degree to which stakeholders simply feel the organization is right or wrong (Black, 1993; Skitka et al., 2005).

We suggest that rational, emotional, and moral concerns are present in varying degrees across and within a variety of stakeholder groups during a crisis. By focusing on these concerns, we are able to retain the complexity that comes with theorizing about multiple and disparate stakeholder groups without being constrained by specific groups (e.g., employees, shareholders, customers) whose labels may not necessarily reflect the members' underlying concerns. That is, by developing theory at the mechanistic level, we are able to integrate both within- and between-stakeholder group heterogeneity.

An incident with Procter & Gamble's (P&G) Rely brand helps illustrate stakeholders' multiple concerns during a crisis. In 1980, Rely tampons were linked to toxic shock syndrome, a potentially fatal condition. This issue raised rational concerns among stakeholders about the company's ability to make reliable products. The company, which "earned a well-deserved reputation for meticulous, exhaustive market research and test marketing before introducing a product" was now "suddenly and without warning linked to a number of deaths, attributed to a

mysterious-sounding disease" (Fink, 1986: 191). In such situations, stakeholders look for information in order to make rational conclusions about the organization and its actions. As Coombs (2011: 148) noted, "On a basic level, stakeholders need to know what happened: the *what, when, where, why,* and *how* of the crisis" Mitigating rational concerns thus includes providing stakeholders with the information they need to make conclusions about the crisis, as well as information that reaffirms the organization's ability to deliver value.

Another concern for P&G, however, was the emotion the crisis evoked. The thought of a popular, over-the-counter hygiene product causing such harm instilled a sense of anxiety and fear among regulators, consumers, and the public. Indeed, "a feeling of panic had slowly crept into the homes of American women" (Wilson, 2003: 313). As we will explore, mitigating such concerns includes inducing positive emotions among stakeholders or reducing their negative emotions toward the offending organization.

Finally, this crisis brought on moral concerns that P&G's views on safety might be incongruent with societal views. This apprehension had economic ramifications for the company, as many women "chose safety over convenience and switched to using [other products]" (Wilson, 2003: 335). Such moral concerns induce stakeholders to compare their values and beliefs to those of the organization (Rindova & Martins, 2018). Mitigating moral concerns thus includes actions that realign the organization with stakeholders' values or alter perceptions about the degree of value incongruity in the offending organization.

As the example highlights, a crisis is likely to evoke all three concerns among stakeholders, at least to a degree. However, the degree to which the concerns are (a) salient in the crisis and (b) the primary motivator for stakeholders are important factors in whether they are relevant for an organization to address. For any given stakeholder, this may be a function of the type of crisis (e.g., environmental malfeasance, financial restatements), its magnitude (i.e., the breadth and depth of its impact), or the stakeholders' relationship with the organization (i.e., high-identification stakeholders vs. low-identification stakeholders) (Bundy et al., 2017). The stakeholder concerns we highlight incorporate these components implicitly. Thus, by focusing on stakeholders' heterogenous sociocognitive concerns as our central mechanism, rather than the different groups they populate, we are better able to identify the potential trade-offs an organization faces while remaining agnostic of the individual stakeholder(s) making the evaluation.

Next, we build a typology that juxtaposes two primary components of an organization's crisis response strategy—how it handles crisis *accountability* (the extent to which an organization accepts responsibility for its role in causing the crisis) and how it directs stakeholders' *attention* (the extent to which an organization brings attention toward the crisis and possible remedies) (Bundy et al., 2017; Zavyalova et al., 2012)—to explain how crisis response strategies address stakeholders' rational, emotional, and moral concerns in different ways.

Our theorizing is guided by three primary conditions. First, we focus on organizations' initial response strategies to the crisis, as well as stakeholders' initial attempts to make sense of it (Bundy & Pfarrer, 2015; Fink, 1986; Mitroff, 1994; Turner, 1976; Veil, 2011; Wang, Reger, & Pfarrer, 2021). During this critical time period, organizations and their leaders typically seek to have a single, unified voice to manage the widespread impact on a range of stakeholders (e.g., Bundy & Pfarrer, 2015; Pfarrer, DeCelles, et al., 2008; Yu, Sengul, & Lester, 2008). Second, we develop our theory from the perspective of the organization and its understanding of stakeholders' sociocognitive concerns. That is, we consider how the organization's successful implementation of different response strategies is expected to influence stakeholders' various concerns as outcomes of crisis management. Third, we assume that stakeholders assign some level of responsibility to the organization for causing the crisis. Without this assumption, stakeholders would not necessarily have rational, emotional, and moral concerns directed at the organization—that is, there would be no crisis for the organization to manage.

RESPONSE STRATEGIES AND STAKEHOLDERS' SOCIOCOGNITIVE CONCERNS

A crisis response strategy is a "set of coordinated communication and actions used to influence evaluators' crisis perceptions" (Bundy & Pfarrer, 2015: 346). While there are multiple categorization schemes of crisis responses (e.g., Ashforth & Gibbs, 1990; Benoit, 1995; Coombs, 1995; Lamin & Zaheer, 2012; Lange & Washburn, 2012; Marcus & Goodman, 1991; Sutton & Callahan, 1987; Zavyalova et al., 2012), most derive their logic from attribution theory (Kelley & Michela, 1980) and are constructed along a continuum of accommodation, which represents the degree to which the organization acknowledges its perceived causal role in a crisis (Bottom, Gibson, Daniels, & Murnighan, 2002; Bundy & Pfarrer, 2015; Coombs & Holladay, 2004; Pfarrer, DeCelles, et al., 2008). More accommodative responses include

apologies, statements of sympathy, and announcing corrective actions, whereas less accommodative (sometimes called defensive) responses include denials, scapegoating, and excuses or justifications (Bundy et al., 2017).

For example, Marcus and Goodman (1991: 291) coded response strategies as accommodative if managers "accepted responsibility" and defensive if they "insisted that problems did not exist." Other researchers have used consistent categorizations, sometimes with different labels (e.g., "denial" and "acknowledgement" [Elsbach, 1994]; "concealing," "accepting responsibility," and "denying responsibility" [Sutton & Callahan, 1987]), likely because this conceptualization allows for easier empirical identification of response strategies. For instance, if an organization says it is "donating nearly $1 million in aid to the victims and is planning to set up an orphanage" (Marcus & Goodman, 1991: 291), or that it is "implementing some change in a firm's organization-wide policies" (Lamin & Zaheer, 2012: 50) these statements can both be labeled accommodative, as each, at least implicitly, acknowledges a degree of responsibility.

Yet, while useful, this view of response strategies may oversimplify their complexity. For instance, while both setting up an orphanage and implementing organization-wide policies are examples of accommodative actions (Marcus & Goodman, 1991), they "accommodate" in distinct ways. More specifically, the former takes attention away from the organization's operations, while the latter draws attention toward them. Additionally, while each response may signal a degree of implicit accountability, neither is contingent upon the organization actually accepting responsibility. Indeed, a food manufacturer can deny its role in causing food poisoning while also providing financial compensation to those afflicted. Similarly, organizations can implement changes in hiring policies following the publicity of another organization's discriminatory hiring practices. Thus, organizations can be more, or less, accommodative in different ways. Extant identification approaches are therefore problematic because, as we will explore, differences in these responses may lead to distinct outcomes. By oversimplifying response strategies, we may not be accurately capturing their differential effects on organizations and stakeholders.

Recognizing this issue, some scholars have begun to consider alternative ways in which a response strategy is framed. For example, Zavyalova and colleagues (2012) recognized that organizations' responses can be either "ceremonial" or "technical," with ceremonial responses aimed at directing stakeholder attention away from the crisis and technical responses directing stakeholder attention toward the crisis and possible remedies. While such a focus on stakeholder attention works to capture a different dimension of a response strategy (e.g., Chandler, 2015), it unfortunately ignores attributions of responsibility. As such, it maintains a limitation in that it remains unidimensional.

Extending past research, we move away from the proliferation—and limitations—of response strategy labels (e.g., accommodative, defensive, ceremonial, technical) to instead focus on their mechanisms. In particular, and drawing on the previous literature, we define two dimensions of response strategies: *accountability* (the extent to which an organization accepts responsibility for its role in causing the crisis) and *attention* (the extent to which an organization brings attention toward the crisis and possible remedies). Throughout our subsequent theorizing, we will examine the degree to which high and low levels of the accountability and attention dimensions in an organization's response strategy address stakeholders' rational, emotional, and moral concerns.[1] Table 2 acts as a guide for our first four propositions.

How Accountability Addresses Stakeholders' Sociocognitive Concerns

High levels of accountability. High-accountability responses accept more responsibility for the organization's perceived role in a crisis (Bundy & Pfarrer, 2015). An example is West Pharmaceutical Services's (WPS's) response to a 2004 explosion in one of its facilities. After the incident, the company immediately acknowledged the presence of combustible dust and its noncompliance with fire safety codes that contributed to the explosion (Coombs, 2013). We theorize that high-accountability responses have a high likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' rational concerns, but a low likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' emotional and moral concerns.

First, high-accountability responses generally enable organizations to address rational concerns by

[1] For clarity, we categorize response strategies as ideal types while recognizing their continuous nature (Fiss, 2011). That is, while we recognize that each dimension may exist on a continuum (i.e., low to high levels of accountability and low to high levels of attention), we treat them as discrete categories in order to develop our typology and more parsimonious theory.

TABLE 2
Crisis Response Strategy Dimensions

Dimension		**Accountability**		**Attention**	
Definition		**The extent to which an organization accepts responsibility for its role in the crisis**		**The extent to which an organization brings attention to the crisis and possible remedies**	
Level of response strategy		***High* (*Proposition 1*)**	***Low* (*Proposition 2*)**	***High* (*Proposition 3*)**	***Low* (*Proposition 4*)**
Likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' sociocognitive concerns	*Rational*	[+] Meets stakeholders' informational demands	[–] Does not meet stakeholders' informational demands	[+] Reassures stakeholders of organization's capabilities	[–] Does not address organizational capabilities
	Emotional	[–] Does not clearly enhance positive affect or reduce negative affect	[+] Redirects negative affect away from organization	[–] Does not clearly enhance positive affect or reduce negative affect	[+] Increases positive affect toward organization
	Moral	[–] Organization admits to immoral behavior	[+] Redirects perceptions of immorality away from organization	[+] Signals that organization is providing a remedy to the situation	[+] Demonstrates value congruence through unrelated moral acts
Example		West Pharmaceutical Services's acknowledgement of noncompliance with safety codes that led to a facility explosion	Pepsi's rejection of allegations regarding syringes found inside its products	Cadbury's investigation of salmonella in its products	Hasbro's discussion of donations in memory of Pearl Harbor veterans following a product recall

meeting stakeholders' needs for attributing crisis responsibility. By clarifying the organization's role in the crisis, this response can satisfy stakeholders' informational demands. For example, by taking responsibility for the crisis, WPS moved stakeholders down a path of understanding—from confusion to consideration—a necessary element of rational assessments (Slovic et al., 2004). We note that moving stakeholders down this path does not necessarily suggest that stakeholders will more positively evaluate the organization's ability to deliver value (Coombs, 2011; Ulmer, Seeger, & Sellnow, 2007). It will, however, allow stakeholders to make such evaluations when they may otherwise assume the worst (e.g., Kruglanski & Webster, 1996). Clarity is thus a necessary condition of mitigating rational sociocognitive concerns, and a high-accountability response provides clarity by unambiguously identifying who is responsible for the crisis.

Second, high-accountability responses are generally less effective at enabling organizations to address stakeholders' emotional concerns. Research on emotions has recognized that positive and negative affect exist on two dimensions and can thus co-occur (Brief & Weiss, 2002; Elfenbein, 2007; Lindquist & Barrett, 2008). That is, one can feel positive affect toward an organization for not shying away from taking accountability for a crisis while also feeling negative affect toward the same organization for creating a hazardous product—a concept known as emotional ambivalence (Fong, 2006; Koch, 1987). Mitigating emotional concerns thus requires organizations to either (a) clearly reduce the negative affect stakeholders feel toward the organization, (b) clearly enhance the positive affect, or (c) both.

At its best, however, being accountable tends to send *mixed* emotional cues. On the one hand, accountability can mitigate questions about whether the organization cares about its various stakeholders (Patel & Reinsch, 2003), and ameliorate animosity toward offenders (Kellerman, 2006). On the other hand, taking responsibility for a crisis may make the organization a target for stakeholder resentment because of the confirmed association between the organization and a negative event (Bundy & Pfarrer, 2015). Indeed, in taking responsibility for its role in causing an explosion, WPS's stakeholders may have felt more positively toward the organization for showing concern about their welfare while still feeling angry that the crisis happened in the first place. Since the net valence of the additionally induced affect is unclear, this response has a lower likelihood of mitigating emotional concerns.

Finally, high-accountability responses are also generally less effective at addressing stakeholders' moral concerns, again because they can send mixed cues. At a high level, organizations can address moral concerns in two ways: first, by shifting perceptions of immorality related to the crisis away from the organization, and second, by engaging in acts that signal value congruence between the organization and its stakeholders. A high-accountability response sends mixed cues because it does not clearly offer either of these two solutions.

For example, high-accountability responses may send signals of value congruence. Indeed, some stakeholders may view a high-accountability response as congruent with the norms of society, particularly in places where "personal responsibility" is highly valued, such as in the United States (Black, 1993; Deephouse et al., 2017). In this way, stakeholders may have viewed WPS's response as the "honest" or "right" thing to do, and as a signal that the organization shares their values. At the same time, however, in providing a high-accountability response, the organization also acknowledges its responsibility for an offense that may go *against* stakeholders' values or expectations (Ferrin & Dirks, 2003; Kim, Ferrin, Cooper, & Dirks, 2004). In this way, rather than the organization shifting perceptions of immorality away from itself, it calls direct attention to the immoral event and the organization's responsibility. As such, a high-accountability response may risk ostracizing the organization from stakeholders who view it as guilty of a moral violation (Black, 1993; Devers et al., 2009; Heckert & Heckert, 2002; Tost, 2011). Those trying to make sense of their moral assessments of an offending organization may thus be left with mixed cues at best, and with perceptions of the organization as "deviant" at worst (Heckert & Heckert, 2002: 450). Taken together, we propose:

Proposition 1. A high-accountability response strategy has a high likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' rational concerns, but a low likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' emotional or moral concerns.

Low levels of accountability. Low-accountability responses attempt to reduce an organization's perceived responsibility for a crisis, and include justifications, excuses, scapegoating, and denials (Bundy & Pfarrer, 2015; Coombs & Holladay, 2004; Elsbach, 2003). An example of this response occurred in 1993, when Pepsi rejected allegations of syringes found in its soda cans, stating that this was not a physical possibility during the manufacturing process (Weinstein, 1993). Such efforts attempt to

"sever the connection between the organization and the crisis" and ultimately "reduce organizational responsibility for the crisis" (Coombs, 2013: 10). We theorize that low-accountability responses have a high likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' emotional and moral concerns, but have a low likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' rational concerns.

In our Pepsi example, stakeholders initially blamed the company for the public health crisis (Janofsky, 1993), and many had significant emotional and moral concerns, as media coverage of the issue generated high levels of anguish and fear that put the company's ethics into question (Zinn & Regan, 1993). With regard to stakeholders' emotional concerns, by rejecting or displacing responsibility, a low-accountability response attempts to redirect the anger, disappointment, or disgust caused by the crisis away from the accused organization and toward other entities. In the case of Pepsi, the company defended itself by stating that the crisis was not its fault and that it was an issue of product tampering by consumers (Magiera, 1993). In this way, while stakeholders still had emotional concerns resulting from the crisis, most of these concerns were redirected away from Pepsi and toward other offending entities. Thus, the clarity with which low-accountability responses diffuse affective reactions makes it highly likely for this response to mitigate stakeholders' emotional concerns.

With regard to moral concerns, low-accountability responses attempt to remove the responsibility of the accused organization for the crisis, such that stakeholders do not attribute the morally questionable actions associated with the crisis to the organization (e.g., Antonetti & Baghi, 2021). Similar to how this response redirects stakeholders' negative emotions, it also attempts to redirect any concerns of impropriety away from the focal organization. As such, low-accountability responses are also likely to mitigate stakeholders' moral concerns (Brown, Buchholtz, & Dunn, 2016; Kim et al., 2004). In the Pepsi case, this means that stakeholders were encouraged to hold outside entities as morally accountable for the crisis and to perceive Pepsi as in compliance with societal norms and expectations.

In contrast, we suggest that low-accountability responses have a low likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' rational concerns in a crisis. This is because, unlike high-accountability responses, low-accountability responses typically do not provide enough information for stakeholders to rationally attribute responsibility for the crisis (Slovic et al., 2004). When an organization diminishes its role in a crisis, stakeholders may be unsure to whom they should attribute the crisis and the severity of its impact (Coombs, 2011; Ulmer & Sellnow, 2002). This lack of clarity leaves stakeholders demanding more information, which is critical to arriving at conclusions surrounding the at-fault party (Weiner, 1986). Left with no other target, stakeholders retain their rational concerns of the focal organization (Coombs, 2011).

More specifically, while a low-accountability strategy redirects emotional and moral concerns away from the offending organization, it may not clarify how stakeholders should make sense of their rational concerns stemming from the crisis. That is, from a rational perspective, even if stakeholders no longer attribute negativity or immorality to the focal organization, unanswered questions may still exist regarding who is responsible for the crisis—if it was not Pepsi, then who was it?—leaving stakeholders with the cognitive task of finding answers. In this way, this process is akin to a court of law. When a defendant admits guilt (a high-accountability response), the discovery process is typically halted. However, when a defendant denies guilt (a low-accountability response), the discovery process is required, even if that denial comes with additional explanation and information on who might be responsible (e.g., Antonetti & Baghi, 2021). The court is still required to complete the cognitive task of confirming the denial and obtaining the "other side of the story." Taken together, we propose:

Proposition 2. A low-accountability response strategy has a high likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' emotional and moral concerns, but a low likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' rational concerns.

How Attention Addresses Stakeholders' Sociocognitive Concerns

High levels of attention. High-attention responses bring attention toward the crisis and its possible remedies, typically by highlighting an organization's operations and processes (Zavyalova et al., 2012). Organizations communicating high-attention responses generally signal transparency in their procedures. For example, in 2006, several cases of salmonella led Cadbury, the United Kingdom's "Most Trusted Chocolate Brand," to recall over a million of its products (Coombs, 2013: 65). In response, Cadbury "worked with the government to locate the source of the contamination and then took action to eliminate the source of contamination"

(Coombs, 2013: 65). In doing so, the company publicly disclosed how it tested its products to investigate the source and find a solution.

We theorize that high-attention responses have a high likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' rational and moral concerns, but a low likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' emotional concerns. In the case of Cadbury, stakeholders demanded information relating to the quality of the company's products and capabilities. A high-attention response clearly addresses this information demand. Since high-attention responses open the black box of an organization's operations, stakeholders have a better understanding of how the organization is addressing the problem, which research has suggested is effective in recovering from wrongdoing (Coombs, 2007; Mishina et al., 2012; Pfarrer, DeCelles, et al., 2008; Zavyalova et al., 2012). In this way, by bringing attention to the crisis and the organization's operational response, high-attention responses can address stakeholders' rational concerns.

Similarly, high-attention responses are generally more likely to mitigate stakeholders' moral concerns because they incorporate acts that signal value congruence between the organization and its stakeholders. For example, in demonstrating transparency, Cadbury helped to quell moral concerns about whether its processes were in line with industry and societal norms. Indeed, in guiding attention toward its operations and the investigation, as well as cooperating with government officials, Cadbury signaled that it held the same set of values and norms as its customers, the public, and the government, which may have helped in maintaining a perception of morality (Black, 1993). While this method of addressing concerns is unlikely to shift perceptions of immorality away from the organization, it provides a clearly positive moral signal that can realign the organization with stakeholder values (Ham & van den Bos, 2010; Schwartz, 1994). Moreover, unlike a high-accountability response, a high-attention response does not come with the added moral baggage of an explicit acceptance of responsibility. As such, we theorize that it is likely to mitigate moral concerns.

In contrast, high-attention responses are unlikely to mitigate stakeholders' emotional concerns. For Cadbury, such concerns may have stemmed from reactions to the consequences of the crisis, including food poisoning and death. In this sense, high-attention responses neither shift negative attention away from the offending organization nor focus on inducing positive emotions by discussing positive information about the organization (Ashforth & Gibbs, 1990; Zavyalova et al., 2012). Rather, these responses provide conflicting emotional signals. On the one hand, stakeholders' emotional concerns may be alleviated because the organization is drawing attention to resolving the issue (e.g., Kellerman, 2006; Patel & Reinsch, 2003). On the other hand, high-attention responses may induce *additional* negative emotions, as was the case with Cadbury, precisely because they draw attention to the actual crisis itself (Coombs, 2013; Greifeneder, Bless, & Pham, 2011). Through high-attention responses, organizations are thus not providing the positively valenced information that would address stakeholders' emotional concerns (Zajonc, 1980). Since the net valence of the additionally induced affect is unclear, this response has a lower likelihood of mitigating emotional concerns. Taken together, we propose:

Proposition 3. A high-attention response strategy has a high likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' rational and moral concerns, but a low likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' emotional concerns.

Low levels of attention. Low-attention responses take attention away from the crisis and its possible remedies, typically avoiding discussion of an organization's operations and processes (Zavyalova et al., 2012). In particular, these responses often include an organization announcing unrelated news, such as a charitable donation or new product (Ashforth & Gibbs, 1990). For example, following a 2001 product recall, toy maker Hasbro announced that "to … commemorate the heroes that served during the Pearl Harbor attack, [the firm is making] a donation to the USS Arizona Memorial Fund" (Zavyalova et al., 2012: 1084).

We theorize that a low-attention response has a high likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' emotional and moral concerns, but a low likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' rational concerns. First, low-attention responses provide information about something positive attributed to the organization, thus inducing positive affect. For example, when Hasbro brought attention to its donations in the name of fallen Pearl Harbor heroes (Ashforth & Gibbs, 1990; Zavyalova et al., 2012), it hoped that stakeholders would react positively and turn their attention away from the company's recall, thus reducing their emotional concerns surrounding the organization and the crisis.[2] It thus follows that a

[2] We are not suggesting that stakeholders no longer feel any negative affect toward the organization. Rather, the organization's clear induction of positive affect is what allows us to conclude that this response reduces emotional

low-attention strategy is likely to mitigate emotional concerns.

Similarly, low-attention responses provide an avenue to mitigate stakeholders' moral concerns. This is because such responses have the potential to signal value congruence between the organization and its stakeholders. Low-attention responses evoke a sense of goodness or righteousness. Indeed, they "appear to adhere to the norms and expectations of the larger social context in which an organization operates and to promote the belief that the organization's activities are congruent with the values and expectations of its stakeholders" (Kirsch, Goldfarb, & Gera, 2009; Zavyalova et al., 2012: 1085). For example, by announcing a charitable donation, an organization signals that it shares certain values that align with stakeholders' values. In the case of Hasbro, those stakeholders who may have attributed misaligned morals to the company because of its faulty products would have adjusted their perceptions following Hasbro's support for the Pearl Harbor heroes.[3]

In contrast, low-attention responses do not necessarily help stakeholders to rationally reevaluate the organization as a functioning entity (Slovic et al., 2004). While a low-attention response might reduce the salience of rational concerns, it does little to address the actual concerns. That is, rational concerns about an organization's ability to deliver consistent, high-quality output (e.g., toys) may be less salient to stakeholders following low-attention responses that turn their attention toward a positive act unrelated to the organization. However, such concerns are not necessarily mitigated by deflecting attention away from the crisis and the organization's operations. In this sense, a low-attention response may send, at best, mixed cues to address stakeholders' rational concerns. Taken together, we propose:

Proposition 4. A low-attention response strategy has a high likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' emotional and moral concerns, but a low likelihood of mitigating stakeholders' rational concerns.

Returning to Table 2, we see that high and low levels of accountability and attention vary in how likely they are to mitigate stakeholders' rational, emotional, and moral concerns. In particular, high levels of accountability (Proposition 1) and attention (Proposition 3) are similar in that they both have a high likelihood of mitigating rational concerns but a low likelihood of mitigating emotional concerns. However, they are distinct in that high-attention responses have a high likelihood of mitigating moral concerns while high-accountability ones do not.

Additionally, on the surface there are similarities between low-accountability (Proposition 2) and low-attention (Proposition 4) responses. Both, for example, have a high likelihood of mitigating emotional and moral concerns and a low likelihood of mitigating rational concerns. A closer look, however, shows that these responses mitigate concerns in different ways. For example, low-accountability responses redirect negative affect away from an organization, whereas low-attention responses increase positive affect toward an organization. This distinction becomes more apparent when we complete our typology by examining the combinatory effects of crisis response strategies.

Completing the Typology

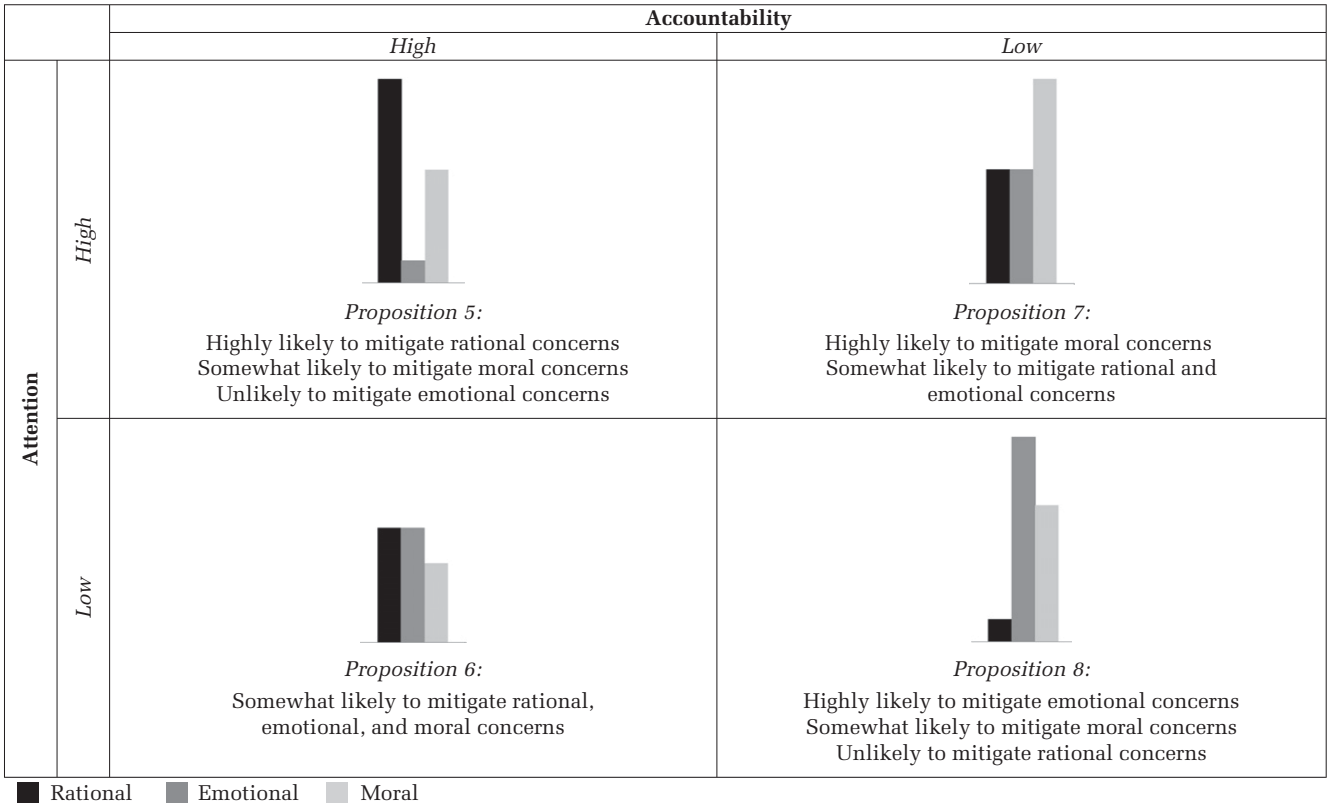
By juxtaposing both dimensions of response strategies, we are able to complete our typology and understand the trade-offs that organizations make when implementing a given response strategy. Figure 1 illustrates this trade-off. The figure is divided into four quadrants, each representing a combination of high or low accountability and high or low attention. The quadrants showcase the likelihood that the crisis response strategy mitigates each type of stakeholder concern. The figure is relative, with taller bars representing a higher likelihood that the response strategy combination addresses that type of concern compared to the other types of concerns.[4]

concerns. Of course, the most effective response to emotional concerns is one that both induces positive affect *and* reduces negative affect toward the organization. We further explore this when combining the attribution and attention dimensions of response strategies.

[3] As with our discussion of emotional concerns, low-attention responses do not completely shift perceptions of immorality (as it relates to the crisis specifically) away from the organization. However, the clear signal of value congruence allows us to conclude that this response is more likely to reduce moral concerns.

[4] Figure 1 also allows for comparison across strategies. For instance, comparing the bottom-left quadrant (i.e., high-attribution, low-attention strategies) with the top-left quadrant (i.e., high-attribution, high-attention strategies) shows that (a) a high-attribution, high-attention strategy is more likely to mitigate rational concerns; (b) a high-attribution, low-attention strategy is more likely to mitigate emotional concerns; and (c) a high-attribution, high-attention strategy is more likely to mitigate emotional concerns.

FIGURE 1
How Crisis Response Strategies Mitigate Stakeholders' Sociocognitive Concerns



High-accountability, high-attention response strategies. Consider, for example, a high-accountability, high-attention response strategy (top-left quadrant of Figure 1). Since both a high-accountability and a high-attention response have a high likelihood of mitigating rational concerns, it follows that this combined response strategy is highly likely to mitigate rational concerns. Indeed, a high-accountability response meets stakeholders' informational demands about responsibility and a high-attention response reassures stakeholders of the organization's capabilities. In contrast, since both responses evoke unclear emotional reactions from stakeholders, their combination is unlikely to mitigate emotional concerns. Finally, whereas high-accountability responses have a low likelihood of mitigating moral concerns, high-attention responses send positive moral signals that the organization is remedying the situation. A response strategy that combines the two is thus somewhat likely to mitigate moral concerns. Returning to Figure 1, the black bar (representing rational concerns) is the tallest, followed by the light gray bar (representing moral concerns) and then by the dark gray bar (representing emotional concerns).

> *Proposition 5. A high-accountability, high-attention crisis response strategy is highly likely to mitigate stakeholders' rational concerns, is somewhat likely to mitigate stakeholders' moral concerns, and is unlikely to mitigate stakeholders' emotional concerns.*

High-accountability, low-attention response strategies. We apply similar logic to derive the other quadrants of Figure 1. A high-accountability, low-attention response strategy (illustrated in the bottom-left quadrant of Figure 1) leads to a similar likelihood of mitigating all three types of concerns, with a slightly lower likelihood of mitigating moral concerns. High-accountability responses address rational concerns by providing stakeholders with information, while low-attention responses do not answer questions about the crisis (Coombs, 2007). Similarly, low-attention responses address emotional concerns by inducing positive affect, while high-accountability

responses send mixed emotional cues (Fong, 2006; Hill, Matta, & Mitchell, 2021; Koch, 1987). Finally, on the surface, this strategy's response to moral concerns is consistent with its response to rational and emotional concerns because one dimension addresses moral concerns while the other does not. It is worth noting, however, that combinations of response dimensions are not strictly additive. This strategy's response to moral concerns is slightly more complex because of an inconsistency in behaviors. While low-attention responses address moral concerns by sending signals of moral congruence, they are offset by high-accountability responses, which admit to moral wrongdoing. Therefore, this clash leads to a reduction in the likelihood that high-accountability, low-attention responses will mitigate moral concerns.

Proposition 6. A high-accountability, low-attention crisis response strategy is somewhat likely to mitigate stakeholders' rational, emotional, and moral concerns.

Low-accountability, high-attention response strategies. Turning to the top-right quadrant of Figure 1, a low-accountability, high-attention response strategy is highly likely to mitigate moral concerns and somewhat likely to mitigate rational and emotional concerns. A low-accountability response redirects perceptions of immorality away from the organization and a high-attention response signals that the organization is helping to remedy the situation, both of which address moral concerns in complementary ways—that is, showing righteousness related to the crisis *and* unrelated to the crisis. At the same time, our theorizing suggests that this strategy is only somewhat likely to mitigate rational concerns because while a high-attention response reassures stakeholders of the organization's capabilities, a low-accountability response likely adds little additional value, since it leaves stakeholders' questions unanswered. Similarly, this strategy is only somewhat likely to address stakeholders' emotional concerns. While a low-accountability response redirects negative affect away from the organization, a high-attention response may amplify negative affect as it calls additional attention to the crisis.

Proposition 7. A low-accountability, high-attention crisis response strategy is highly likely to mitigate stakeholders' moral concerns and is somewhat likely to mitigate stakeholders' rational and emotional concerns.

Low-accountability, low-attention response strategies. Finally, a low-accountability, low-attention response strategy (illustrated in the bottom-right quadrant of Figure 1) is highly likely to mitigate emotional concerns, somewhat likely to mitigate moral concerns, and unlikely to mitigate rational concerns. A low-accountability response redirects negative affect away from the organization, which is complemented by a low-attention response that increases positive affect toward the organization. A low-accountability, low-attention response strategy thus provides clear solutions to address emotional concerns in two distinct ways. Conversely, while low-accountability and low-attention responses are both more likely to mitigate moral concerns, they do so in similar ways. More specifically, as opposed to showing righteousness related to the crisis *and* unrelated to the crisis (as is the case with a high-accountability, low-attention response strategy), they both provide a solution unrelated to the crisis. Thus, even though both responses individually have a high likelihood of mitigating moral concerns, their combination is not entirely additive because of the overlap in how they address moral concerns. Finally, since neither low-accountability nor low-attention responses provide clear solutions to rational concerns, this response strategy is unlikely to mitigate them.

Proposition 8. A low-accountability, low-attention crisis response strategy is highly likely to mitigate stakeholders' emotional concerns, is somewhat likely to mitigate stakeholders' moral concerns, and is unlikely to mitigate stakeholders' rational concerns.

The combined response strategies bring about interesting questions for organizational performance and survival. For example, given its potential to mitigate all three types of concerns, is a low-accountability, high-attention response strategy necessarily *more effective* than the others? One way to answer this question is to examine the effects of crisis response strategies on important, proximal organizational outcomes.

Thus, in the next section we consider the effects of our typology on an organization's social evaluations—stakeholders' socially constructed and collective perceptions of the organization and its actions (e.g., Ashforth & Gibbs, 1990; Benoit, 1995; Bundy & Pfarrer, 2015; Gomulya & Boeker, 2014; Lamin & Zaheer, 2012; Lange & Washburn, 2012; Sutton & Callahan, 1987). In particular, we suggest that stakeholders' rational, emotional, and moral concerns act as the mechanisms by which an organization's reputation, celebrity, legitimacy, and status are threatened during a crisis (e.g., Deephouse et al., 2017; Lange et al., 2011; Pollock et al., 2019; Washington & Zajac, 2005; Zavyalova et al., 2017). In considering how an organization's response strategy mitigates some

TABLE 3
Applying the Typology to Organizations' Social Evaluations

Construct	Sociocognitive Composition	Most Effective Response Strategy for Mitigating Losses	Least Effective Response Strategy for Mitigating Losses
Organizational Reputation	Predominantly rational	High-accountability, high-attention (*Proposition 9a*)	Low-accountability, low-attention (*Proposition 9b*)
Organizational Celebrity	Predominantly emotional	Low-accountability, low-attention (*Proposition 10a*)	High-accountability, high-attention (*Proposition 10b*)
Organizational Legitimacy	Rational, emotional, and moral, with moral as most central	Low-accountability, high-attention (*Proposition 11a*)	High-accountability, high-attention (*Proposition 11b*)
Organizational Status	Rational, emotional, and moral, with rational and moral more central than emotional	Low-accountability, high-attention (*Proposition 12a*)	Low-accountability, low-attention (*Proposition 12b*)

stakeholder concerns but not others, we can apply our theory in practice to consider how an organization's response connects directly to critical outcomes of crisis management.

Applying the Typology

Social evaluations are particularly relevant outcomes of crisis response strategies as they are based on stakeholder interpretations and expectations of organizations' behaviors (Mishina & Devers, 2012; Pollock et al., 2019; Rindova et al., 2012). Given their properties, a useful way of comparing different social evaluations is by examining their respective sociocognitive makeup (Pollock et al., 2019). In particular, research has argued that social evaluations are made of three primary sociocognitive aspects that correspond to the types of stakeholder concerns we delineated earlier: rational, emotional, and moral (Pollock et al., 2019). The rational aspect of social evaluations "reflects audiences' efforts to make reasoned assessments of a firm's capabilities or worth" (Camerer et al., 2005; Pollock et al., 2019: 446; Slovic et al., 2004). The emotional aspect of evaluations refers to stakeholders' affective judgments of an organization's outcomes and actions (Zajonc, 1980). Finally, the moral aspect of social evaluations represents stakeholder judgments of an organization's norms and values (Black, 1993; Devers et al., 2009) and the extent to which these values are in line with stakeholders' understanding of right and wrong (Rindova & Martins, 2018). Together, these aspects help us understand the mechanisms through which different social evaluations are built.

Below, we map the distinct sociocognitive content of four specific social evaluations—reputation, status, celebrity, and legitimacy—onto our typology of crisis management strategies in order to identify the most effective response strategy combination for managing each construct.[5] This mapping exercise allows us to more specifically explicate the potential trade-offs that managers face in a crisis, and the likely prioritization that occurs when organizations implement a response strategy. A critical conclusion of this exercise is that no one strategy best manages all of an organization's social evaluations, and some strategies that more effectively manage one evaluation may in fact be detrimental to others. Table 3 acts as a summary and guide throughout this exercise.

Organizational reputation. An organization's reputation reflects the "ability of an organization to deliver value" (Jensen, Kim, & Kim, 2012: 141; see also Lange et al., 2011). As such, an organization's reputation is built largely via rational sociocognitive content (Pollock et al., 2019). For example, stakeholders perceive reputation as a "signal of quality" (Rindova, Williamson, Petkova, & Sever, 2005: 1035) manifested in an organization's goods and services (e.g., Moran & Ghoshal, 1999), achievements and certifications (e.g., Graffin & Ward, 2010; Rindova et al., 2005), and portrayals in the media as credible or being known for certain valued attributes (e.g., Roberts & Dowling, 2002). While these signals may contain elements of emotion and morality—indeed, media coverage of organizations may evoke emotion, and expertise in an area may relate to morals—stakeholders' assessments of an

[5] We focus on these four social evaluations for three primary reasons. First, our focus stems from the need to identify evaluations that vary across the three sociocognitive aspects. Second, each of these social evaluations are considered "assets," suggesting that an organization would want to mitigate losses to them in a crisis. Finally, these four are among the most-studied social evaluations in management theory, providing a rich foundation upon which to build (Deephouse et al., 2017; Lange et al., 2011; Washington & Zajac, 2005; Zavyalova et al., 2017).

organization's reputation are generally perceived to be dominated by reason, with emotions and morals playing subsidiary roles (Pollock et al., 2019).

Given that an organization's reputation is dependent primarily on the rational aspect, potential reputation losses are most likely to be mitigated via a high-accountability, high-attention response strategy. As illustrated in the top-left quadrant of Figure 1, such a crisis response strategy is highly likely to mitigate rational concerns, somewhat likely to mitigate moral concerns, and unlikely to mitigate emotional concerns. In contrast, a low-accountability, low-attention response strategy can be seen as the least effective option for managing organizational reputation during a crisis, given that it is unlikely to mitigate rational concerns. Thus:

Proposition 9. Losses to an organization's reputation are (a) most likely to be mitigated by a high-accountability, high-attention response strategy, and (b) least likely to be mitigated by a low-accountability, low-attention response strategy.

Organizational celebrity. A celebrity organization is one that "generates high levels of attention and positive emotional responses from stakeholders" (Rindova, Pollock, & Hayward, 2006; Zavyalova et al., 2017: 464). Research has theorized and shown that organizations achieve this positive attention through nonconforming actions that evoke excitement, engagement, and identification among stakeholders (Hubbard, Pollock, Pfarrer, & Rindova, 2018; Pfarrer, Pollock, & Rindova, 2010; Pollock et al., 2019; Zavyalova et al., 2017). As such, celebrity is primarily an emotional evaluation (Pollock et al., 2019; Rindova et al., 2006), and is influenced to a lesser degree by stakeholders' rational and moral perceptions. The nonconformity required for the development of celebrity is incongruent with the premise of the moral dimension of sociocognition, which is built upon conformity to norms (Devers et al., 2009; Rindova & Martins, 2018). Additionally, the dramatic narratives that help create celebrity evoke emotion by telling a protagonist-driven story, while not necessarily requiring rationality (Pfarrer et al., 2010; Rindova et al., 2006; Zavyalova et al., 2017).

Given that an organization's celebrity is dependent primarily on the emotional aspect, potential losses in celebrity are most likely to be mitigated via a low-accountability, low-attention response strategy. As illustrated in the bottom-right quadrant of Figure 1, such a crisis response strategy is highly likely to mitigate emotional concerns, somewhat likely to mitigate moral concerns, and unlikely to mitigate emotional concerns. In contrast, a high-accountability, high-attention response strategy can be seen as the least effective option for managing organizational celebrity during a crisis, given that it is unlikely to mitigate emotional concerns. Thus:

Proposition 10. Losses to an organization's celebrity are (a) most likely to be mitigated by a low-accountability, low-attention response strategy, and (b) least likely to be mitigated by a high-accountability, high-attention response strategy.

Whereas organizational reputation and organizational celebrity are rather "simple" in their sociocognitive makeup, the next two social judgments we examine—organizational legitimacy and organizational status—are more complex in their construction.

Organizational legitimacy. Legitimacy is the "perceived appropriateness of an organization in a social system" (Deephouse et al., 2017: 28). As its definition suggests, legitimacy is built largely on the moral dimension of social evaluations. Indeed, by almost every construal of organizational legitimacy, the importance of societal values, norms, and beliefs is salient (Deephouse et al., 2017). Scholars have consistently demonstrated the importance of these perceptions in establishing and retaining legitimacy among a variety of stakeholders including regulators, licensing boards, the media, and the public (Ruef & Scott, 1998; Tost, 2011).

At the same time, however, research has suggested that stakeholders also rely on their affect toward an organization in determining its legitimacy (Haack, Pfarrer, & Scherer, 2014; Huy, Corley, & Kraatz, 2014), and that legitimacy can also result from "suppositions of rational effectiveness" (Deephouse et al., 2017: 30; see also Meyer & Rowan, 1977; Scott & Lyman, 1968). Thus, taken together, research has suggested that legitimacy is built using all three sociocognitive dimensions, with the moral dimension as the most central (Deephouse et al., 2017; Pollock et al., 2019).

Given that an organization's legitimacy requires positive assessments along multiple aspects (with moral being the most important), potential losses in legitimacy are most likely to be mitigated via a low-accountability, high-attention response strategy. As illustrated in the top-right quadrant of Figure 1, a crisis response strategy that is low in accountability and high in attention is highly likely to mitigate moral concerns and somewhat likely to mitigate

both rational and emotional concerns.[6] In contrast, a high-accountability, high-attention response strategy is unlikely to address the moral concerns that are so critical to mitigating legitimacy losses. As such, it can be seen as the least effective option for managing organizational legitimacy during a crisis. Thus:

Proposition 11. Losses to an organization's legitimacy are (a) most likely to be mitigated by a low-accountability, high-attention response strategy, and (b) least likely to be mitigated by a high-accountability, high-attention response strategy.

Organizational status. Finally, status is "a socially constructed, intersubjectively agreed-upon and accepted ordering or ranking of individuals, groups, organizations, or activities in a social system" (Washington & Zajac, 2005: 284). Status allows organizations to be differentiated not only by perceptions of quality but also by their respective positions in a social hierarchy (Podolny, 1994; Washington & Zajac, 2005). As such, rational content is important to status, and consists of "understanding who the actors that comprise the status hierarchy are, what organizational characteristics determine standing within the status hierarchy, and what relationships define the hierarchy's boundaries and each firm's position within it" (Pollock et al., 2019: 451; see also Sauder, Lynn, & Podolny, 2012).

At the same time, however, these considerations also reflect the moral congruence between organizations and stakeholders (Jasso, 2001; Pollock et al., 2019; Rao, Monin, & Durand, 2005). Research has consistently supported the notion that status positions are built and lost based, in part, on moral perceptions (e.g., Hahl & Zuckerman, 2014; Pollock et al., 2019; Rao et al., 2005). Finally, status also incorporates the emotional aspect of evaluations, although to a lesser degree. For example, high status can evoke positive emotions such as admiration, as well as negative emotions such as exclusion (e.g., Sweetman, Spears, Livingstone, & Manstead, 2013). Taken together, status relies on all three sociocognitive dimensions, with the emotional dimension as slightly less salient (Pollock et al., 2019).

Given that an organization's status requires positive assessments along multiple aspects (with rational and moral being the most important), potential losses in status are most likely to be mitigated via a low-accountability, high-attention response strategy. As illustrated in the top-right quadrant of Figure 1, such a crisis response is highly likely to mitigate moral concerns and somewhat likely to mitigate both rational and emotional concerns. In contrast, a low-accountability, low-attention response strategy is unlikely to address the rational concerns that are critical to mitigating status losses. As such, it can be seen as the least effective option for managing organizational status during a crisis. Thus:

Proposition 12. Losses to an organization's status are (a) most likely to be mitigated by a low-accountability, high-attention response strategy, and (b) least likely to be mitigated by a low-accountability, low-attention response strategy.

DISCUSSION

In this paper, we developed a typology that explored the relative effectiveness of four crisis responses strategies on three stakeholder sociocognitive concerns that arise during a crisis. We provided a more nuanced approach to studying crisis management that makes clear the trade-offs managers face when deciding which strategy to pursue. In doing so, we offer three primary contributions to research.

First, we applied an information-processing perspective to specify three sociocognitive concerns that arise for stakeholders during a crisis (rational, emotional, and moral concerns). Focusing on these sociocognitive concerns as mechanisms allowed us to incorporate both within- and between-stakeholder group heterogeneity into our theorizing without the need to group stakeholders into traditional archetypes (e.g., shareholders, employees, customers). Second, we advanced crisis management research by theorizing about crisis responses along two dimensions (accountability and attention) based on the mechanisms driving their effects. We then used these two dimensions to build a response strategy typology and considered how various response strategies work to differentially address stakeholders' sociocognitive concerns. In addition to contributing to our understanding of audience heterogeneity in the crisis management literature, we add to emerging literature on the nuances and heterogeneities in external organizational communication more broadly (e.g., Ertug et al., 2016; König, Mammen, Luger, Fehn, & Enders, 2018). Finally, we applied our theorizing to

[6] A high-accountability, low-attention response strategy (i.e., the bottom-left quadrant of Figure 1) also has a reasonable likelihood of addressing all three concerns, thus making it an alternative approach. However, since we are interested in identifying the strategy that gives organizations the *highest* likelihood of mitigating losses in legitimacy, a low-accountability, high-attention response is most appropriate.

an organization's social evaluations (reputation, celebrity, legitimacy, and status) to clarify the practical trade-offs associated with crisis response strategies. Below, we discuss the theoretical, empirical, and practical implications of our theory, as well as limitations and directions for future research.

Implications for Research

Our theory has several theoretical implications that relate to aspects of the crisis management process. First, two of the strategies in our typology (a high-accountability, high-attention response and a low-accountability, low-attention response) are more specialized in that they are highly likely to mitigate a specific stakeholder concern. Organizations may want to implement these "one-trick ponies" when a crisis evokes one particular concern more than the others. For example, when a manufacturer initiates a recall, stakeholders may focus on the organization's ability to deliver a valuable product and, as such, their rational concerns may be most salient (Zavyalova et al., 2012).

In contrast, the other two strategies (a high-accountability, low-attention response and a low-accountability, high-attention response) may have a comparable or superior likelihood of mitigating multiple stakeholder concerns, but a lower likelihood of mitigating one particular concern. These "jack-of-all-trades" strategies offer more breadth in the concerns they address. Managers are therefore likely inclined to implement these strategies when faced with threats to multiple social evaluations. For example, when an organization engages in wrong doing, stakeholders may begin to question the organization's morals and develop negative emotional attitudes, thus requiring a response that touches on multiple concerns (Bruyaka, Philippe, & Castañer, 2018). Our typology provides an avenue for future research to further examine this line of thinking.

Relatedly, in looking at Figure 1 it seems implausible that a manager would necessarily choose a high-accountability, low-attention response strategy (bottom-left) over a low-accountability, high-attention response strategy (top-right). If one strategy maintains a higher likelihood of addressing all stakeholder concerns, when (if at all) should managers consider the "worse" of the two? This could be an interesting question for researchers to explore. Our typology offers some guidance, given that the quadrants address stakeholder concerns in distinct ways. In particular, it suggests that the manner in which a concern is addressed can be a point of differentiation between these response strategies.

Our typology makes it easier to understand that there are many factors to consider when choosing between strategies. However, a limitation of our theory is that we were unable to fully consider the various circumstantial or environmental factors influencing managers' decisions. It is important to consider, for example, the type and magnitude of crisis, the degree of information asymmetry between managers and stakeholders, and the salience of the crisis to different stakeholders. Additionally, while we have focused on accountability and attention as the two primary dimensions by which crisis response strategies are built, there may be other dimensions and factors to explore, such as the transparency or the speed of the organization's response. These contingencies likely affect response strategies' likelihood of mitigating concerns in ways that could bolster the explanatory power of the typology. Similarly, we have presented the dimensions of a crisis response strategy—accountability and attention—as distinct. However, cases may exist in which that distinction is less clear, thus making certain strategy combinations less viable. We encourage future research to examine these components, both theoretically and empirically.

As it relates specifically to response strategies, we did not incorporate a nonresponse, or reticence, into our theorizing. Our focus was on situations wherein organizations manage crises by providing additional information to stakeholders (Billings, Milburn, & Schaalman, 1980; Scherer, Palazzo, & Seidl, 2013). It is possible, however, that an organization's assets are best preserved by leaving stakeholders' concerns unaddressed (Wang et al., 2021). Reticence might be a plausible strategy for several reasons, including the notion that the costs to execute a successful response strategy may outweigh its benefits (e.g., a response brings more attention and visibility to the crisis than there was before), the organization's culpability and organizational changes are already transparent, or managers are legally constrained from making public statements. These are important considerations for future scholars interested in further exploring response strategies.

By delineating stakeholders' sociocognitive concerns (rational, emotional, and moral), we emphasized the importance of discerning how stakeholders process, interpret, and use information (e.g., Meindl et al., 1994; Rindova et al., 2012). However, not all concerns may be salient at the onset of a crisis, and not all concerns may be the primary motivator for

stakeholders to feel concerned. How visible or relevant a crisis is to stakeholders may be important factors that determine the salience of their sociocognitive concerns and thus the ones that are triggered. Further exploring the nuances between these types of concerns could be a fruitful avenue of research. Conceptually, incorporating dynamic theorizing wherein researchers vary the concerns in a more nuanced manner could help develop such arguments. Empirically, an appropriate approach could be to combine a field study with an experiment. In this way, researchers would be able to delineate between stakeholders' rational, emotional, and moral concerns such that endogeneity concerns can also be mitigated—while also ensuring external validity. Over time, this approach could be used to build a body of work that examines and compares stakeholders' reactions to crises.

By developing theory at the mechanistic level focused on stakeholders' sociocognitive concerns, we were able to integrate both within- and between-stakeholder group heterogeneity. Empirical investigations of these concerns—including (a) the degree of interrelatedness across concerns, (b) the degree of heterogeneity within and across stakeholder groups for each concern, and (c) the degree to which crisis response strategies address stakeholders' different concerns—would all thus be worthwhile contributions to further unpacking stakeholder heterogeneity.

Implications for Practice

Our typology suggests that how organizations combine accountability and attention in their responses will differentially manage stakeholders' reactions to the crisis, as well as their perceptions of the organization. Since there is no one-size-fits-all response strategy—each has its benefits and drawbacks—it behooves managers and scholars to move away from questions such as, "What is the best response strategy?" and toward questions such as, "What stakeholder concerns should the organization be trying to most effectively manage?"

Indeed, the ambiguity and information asymmetry inherent in a crisis gives managers the opportunity to provide information that is strategically advantageous. To be clear, we do not suggest that organizations engage in unethical behaviors in order to deny culpability. Rather, our typology delineates the options available to managers at the onset of a crisis, and how those options may mitigate losses to the organization's priorities.

CONCLUSION

In this paper, we highlighted the coarse-grained manner in which crisis management research has been typically conducted—that is, its focus on the "best" overall crisis response strategy as opposed to the trade-offs associated with different response strategies. To showcase these trade-offs, we developed a typology that demonstrates the likelihood that two dimensions of crisis responses—accountability and attention—mitigate stakeholders' rational, emotional, and moral concerns. We also applied our typology to understand how response strategies differentially affect an organization's social evaluations. In sum, our theorizing offers a foundation for future researchers interested in accounting for the nuance and complexity associated with crisis response strategies.

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